STATE SCAN

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▶ MADHYA PRADESH

THE BIG DAIRY PUSH

CM Mohan Yadav bets on breed improvement, technology and cooperatives to double milk output, but caste calculus appears to shape the push

By **Rahul Noronha**



DAIRY DRIVE Mohan Yadav with a newborn calf at his residence in Bhopal, which he named Kamala

Within months of taking over as chief minister of Madhya Pradesh in December 2023, Mohan Yadav announced an ambitious plan to more than double milk production in the state over the next five years. The state currently accounts for about 9 per cent of the country's dairy output, a share he aims to raise to 20 per cent. MP ranks third in milk production, behind Uttar Pradesh (16 per cent) and Rajasthan (15 per cent). "We are following a multi-pronged approach to develop the sector," says CM Yadav.

CASTE SUBTEXT?

Political watchers, however, see the dairy push as linked to the CM's caste background. A large share of those engaged in the milk business belong to the Yadav and Pal communities—estimated at around 10 per cent of the state's population. So, strengthening the sector is likely to benefit them. The promotion of dairy aligns with a broader effort to highlight ideas associated with the Yadav identity. For instance, there is a plan to develop a Shri Krishna Pathey Tirth to promote religious destinations linked to Lord Krishna, who holds special significance for the Yadavs. Also in the pipeline are 300 Sandipani schools—the name referencing Krishna's guru—and Gita Bhawans in all urban local bodies. But Yadav denies any narrow focus and maintains that dairy promotion will benefit all.

Breed improvement, feed and vaccination, and milk marketing are the key features of Yadav's new dairy push. According to the 2019 livestock census, nearly 70 per cent of MP's cattle are nondescript—only about 30 per cent have known lineage and yield a reasonable amount of milk. The task is to increase the share of these animal breeds through artificial insemination—and, to some extent, in-vitro fertilisation—and to castrate those that cannot be improved in order to discontinue their genetic line.

Although artificial insemination was widely performed in the state, there was no feedback system. Nor was there any documentation of the offspring breed. "To address this, we decided to train our veterinarians in the latest techniques and eliminate the possibility of 'artificial inseminations on paper', where they simply filled in numbers to meet targets," says Umakant Umarao, principal secretary, animal husbandry. "We have trained the AVFOs (assistant veterinary field officers) in how to communicate and